

**cover story** INDO-US NUCLEAR DEAL

# MANMOHAN MELTDOWN

IT WAS MARKETING AS A DEAL AUTHORED BY A STATESMAN BUT THE PRIME MINISTER'S BRAZEN SOMERSAULT HAS EXPOSED HIM AS A LEADER WHO DID NOT STAND BY HIS CONVICTION. THE INSIDE STORY OF HOW THE GREAT MODERNISER HAS BECOME THE BIGGEST LET-DOWN.

■ By Priya Sahgal and Satarupa Bhattacharjya

**T**here he was, Manmohan Singh the tough-talking prime minister with a missionary zeal, ready to take on his antediluvian tormentors for the sake of his idea of India in the 21st century. With the precision and patience of a man determined to gain his place in history, he considered the nuclear deal with the United States as the *noblesse oblige* of the chosen one. He could not afford to lose it. It was his big moment, his grand gesture as the moderniser. It was such a Big Deal for him. That was then. Today, it is no longer a big deal, and the prime minister has taken a giant leap from unwavering idealism to humiliating pragmatism. Apparently, as the vicissitudes of an accidental political life go, a

nuclear pact should not be allowed to leave you unemployed. Suddenly, Manmohan, till the other day a committed warrior of the cause, has become conveniently philosophical: there has to be a life after the nuclear deal. Unfortunately, it is not a life chosen by himself. It is a life dictated by the unforgiving commissar of the Indian Left. It is a surrender necessitated by the fear of elections—or the lack of courage to stand by one's conviction and pay the political price for it.

Is this transformation the high point of the unravelling of Manmohan, the prime minister for whom politics has always been an occupational hazard? In the beginning, the deal was rhapsodised by its makers as a historic engagement between the world's largest democracies. In retrospect, it

was foolish to assume that such an ambitious project could be completed by diplomatic skills alone. It required solid political will. It was not just a matter of policy. It was politics on a grand scale.

The main player on the Indian side, though, was not a politician with the necessary iron in his soul. Essentially a loyal policy wonk, Manmohan always 'looked up' for political sustenance. When he first caught the nation's—and the world's—attention as the liberator of the market, there was a political master above him to show the path. A technocrat by training, he did the job perfectly for his boss. As a prime minister chosen by Congress President Sonia Gandhi, he kept up the tradition of dutiful obedience. Perhaps for the first time, the prime minister of India is

not the prime mover of Indian politics.

The nuclear deal brought out that reality with devastating effect. For a while, it looked as though this deal would make him politically savvy. When he ridiculed the nuclear-phobia of the comrades in a newspaper interview, it was indeed a bravura performance, though the tone was a bit un-Manmohanish in its aggression. It was, nevertheless, a position well stated—and a show of spine and conviction. It would not last. He didn't have the political skill or experience to win the comrades over or influence the allies. The boss couldn't do it for him either. The foundation for the deal was, after all, laid by the pathbreaking political initiative of the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government. Only an equally audacious political vision could have